

CIRCULAR REASONING



It's a rainy Tuesday, and you and your brother are trying to decide on a board game. You want to play *Kingdom Builder*, but your brother has grabbed the box for *Sneaky Spies* and is hugging it to his chest.

"We're playing *Sneaky Spies*," he announces.

"But we played that yesterday," you say. "I think we should vote. Or maybe take turns choosing."

"No," he says, shaking his head. "I am the Game Captain, so I get to decide."

You blink. "Since when are you the Game Captain?"

"Since right now." He puts a colander from the kitchen on his head like a helmet.

"See? I have the hat."

"But why do *you* get to be the Captain?" you ask.

"Because I'm the one who decides which game we play," he answers, as if this is the most obvious thing in the world.

"But why do you get to decide?"

"Because I'm the Captain!"

You feel a little bit dizzy. You try to follow his logic, but it keeps looping back on itself. He is the Captain because he decides the game. And he decides the game because he is the Captain. There is no actual reason why he should be in charge—he's just using his own rule to prove his own rule. It's like a snake eating its own tail.

He hasn't actually given you a reason; he's just repeated his opinion in a circle.



What your brother did is called "circular reasoning." It is also sometimes called "begging the question."

Imagine you are trying to build a bridge. You need a solid piece of ground on one side to start building from. In an argument, that solid ground is called a "premise" or a reason. It needs to be something different from the thing you are trying to prove.

Circular reasoning happens when someone tries to build the bridge starting from the bridge itself. They say, "I am right because I am right." Or, "This book is the best book because it says on the cover that it's the best."

If you ask someone "Why?" and their answer is just a different version of the first thing they said, they haven't actually answered you. They are running around a logic track, ending up exactly where they started, without getting anywhere new.

How to spot it:

Listen for arguments where the "proof" sounds suspiciously like the claim itself. If you can swap the beginning of the sentence and the end of the sentence and it means the exact same thing (like "I'm in charge because I'm the boss"), you have spotted a circle. Watch for phrases like "because that's just how it is" or definitions used as reasons.

How to respond to it:

You can gently break the circle by asking for a reason that comes from *outside* the loop. "I know you want to be Captain, but *why* should you get to be Captain instead of me?" Asking for a new, separate reason forces them to stop spinning and start thinking.

Something to try:

Listen for circles this week. They happen a lot when people are frustrated.

- "This cereal is the yummiest because it tastes the best." (Yummy and best mean the same thing!)
- "You have to listen to me because I'm the one talking."

When you hear one, imagine a dog chasing its own tail. Write down the argument and draw a circle next to it. And catch yourself, too! If you find yourself saying, "I want it because I want it," stop and try to find a real reason—like "I want it because I'm hungry."